

The Indian market scenario

The Indian mobile games market is growing consistently and the demand for mobile games developers increased by at least 20 per cent last year, believes Najeeb Ilyas, senior technology architect at a reputed MNC. "So far, what I have observed is that the smartphone industry is booming and, hence, the demand for Android games has increased a lot compared to the Java games of the previous era. Android and iOS got operating system upgrades, which in turn improved the performance of games. Companies like Samsung, HTC, LG, etc, have upgraded their mobile hardware to improve the battery's performance and the processing speed. Due to all of this, the demand for game development has increased dramatically," quips Ilyas.

The Indian market is a bit tricky. Any mobile game that needs to be paid for will face resistance in the Indian market. "If you look at the numbers, the market is huge. The smartphone tech-savvy people (or the younger generation) spend a lot of time with their devices. One thing that I have seen is that there is a certain group that keeps exploring games. They download, play for some time, and if they like it, they use it regularly; else, it is uninstalled immediately. There is one more group that constitutes the majority, which downloads and plays a game, and if they do not like it, they do not open it again. The app remains on their devices till they need to make space to accommodate something else," says Swagata.

Monetisation—a critical issue

There are some industry experts who feel the mobile gaming industry is at a very nascent stage in India. Pradeep I S N, who set up the production and research division of the CGManifest Group, feels that in India, people are more interested in free games than in purchasing games via the mobile. "Monetisation is a critical issue for any game entering the Indian market. With free games, we can't go beyond a limit in the market. If we consider the existing opportunities for mobile games developers in India, the majority of them are not into creative product development. Many local and global companies appoint people in India for portability tasks, pixel art-based tasks and a few other bulk jobs but there is very little hiring of developers for core games development. The logic part of most of the games is developed abroad, sent to India for certain post-development, release phase work before the actual release," says Pradeep.

Why HTML5 skills are in demand

HTML5 is the buzzword when it comes to mobile games development. Most skilled developers are unprepared to adjust to the limited games development opportunities in India, so they are now looking to build their own

identities/brands and monetise their games on their own. Since HTML5 provides developers the facility to host and market their games without depending on any particular platform-based app store, people are now slowly turning towards this platform due to its enormous power and the features it supports for Web-based games.

"Also, the smart-gadget revolution has led to customers adopting browser-based games on a large scale now a days; so developers are looking for an alternative solution and HTML5 is perfect for such games. First of all, it is open source and gives a lot of freedom to developers to convert their ideas into virtual-reality at a cheaper or at no cost. The second reason is that the size of the development team required for games created for small gadgets is much smaller. Also, the cost of development is much lower than what it is for console-based games. The support of technologies like SVG and WebGL for HTML5 also plays a key role in developing innovative and powerful games for the Web and mobile," explains Pradeep. Industry pundits definitely expect a bright future for HTML5 in India due to the immense developer resources available in the country.

The other skill sets

According to Rohit Bhosle, a mobile games developer should have the three Ps while developing games—patience and perseverance. "If you have these three Ps, you can probably succeed in this domain. Moreover, you need to explore a lot of games if you wish to develop a high-end game. Games development offers those looking for employment many roles, like the core programmer - the core around which the game comes into existence; and the designer - the one who visualises how the game unfolds from start to finish, and how it feels. The other roles are in management. The producer ensures things are done according to fixed milestones and that inter-dependency needs are always addressed. Another role is that of a product manager who looks after the economic aspects, the overall experience, takes business decisions, oversees marketing, etc. The core development team can make the game, but a management team is required for timely deliveries and to ensure the game gets better exposure," he says.

Swagata feels that the developers should know enough about the game engines available to build upon so that they do not waste time reinventing the wheel. "For example, while doing something that involves physics, I would look for a good physics library that has some APIs, which I can directly use. If I went about writing my own physics library, it can be fun, but the game development process would take that much longer, with someone else probably implementing my idea much faster. So keeping an eye on the trends in games development is another required skill," shares Swagata.